'What year was that?' I asked him, trying to get things in the right perspective. 'Didn't you try to stop him?'

'Sahib, Mustafa tried to kill Mir in order to redeem our family honour but did not succeed. After that, he was branded for life. What choice did he have?'

The anguish and pain in the old man's eyes was all too evident. I could not but help commiserate with him. He had lost a son and I had one of my officers seriously injured in the same encounter.[1] We were both husbands and fathers. The cross was for us to bear. What is right and what is wrong is not for us mere mortals to decide. Razzaq's wife, Roja, and daughters Javeeda and Chaspeeda came to our camp at Malamu the next day looking as anxious as ever. I can imagine they must have spent a sleepless night imagining all kinds of untold horrors that Razzaq might have been going through at our ruthless hands. After seating them on a bench outside the camp (women were never brought into the camp), we asked them a few questions to verify some of the facts given to us by Razzaq. Once satisfied, we brought Razzaq out and reunited him with his family. A faintly worried smile creased Roja's face. One could make out that she must have been a beauty in her younger days. Her daughters were also equally pretty, but Roja outshone them. Some of what Razzaq had told me the previous night made sense. There was a flurry of conversation which we tried to decipher. We could make out a few words. Razzaq turned to us with a smile.

'They are asking me if I have been harmed. I've told them that I have been treated well. We are all grateful.'

'Why should we have harmed him?' I asked Roja.

Chaspeeda, the younger daughter who knew a little Urdu, answered, 'My father has been picked up several times because of Mustafa. He has always been beaten up by the security forces,

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